MODULE 26 · DOMAIN 6 - STAKEHOLDER COMMUNICATION AND LIFECYCLE

Structured Discovery and Requirements

Turning a vague ask into requirements: decomposition, functional and non-functional requirements, success criteria and failure thresholds, workshops, and traceability.

DOMAIN 6 of 7 EXAM WEIGHT 14% MODULE 26 of 38

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Domain 6 at a glance

OBJECTIVE	MODULE
Structured discovery and requirements	26
Communicating decisions and trade-offs	27
Feedback loops and expectations, including SLAs	28
Documenting architectures and implementation guidance	29
Lifecycle phases: discovery, design, handoff, monitoring, iteration	29

ON THE EXAM

The practice questions lean hardest here. Expect more of this domain than its weight suggests.

"I feel ill." A good doctor asks where, since when, and what makes it worse. **Nobody prescribes from the first sentence.**

Decomposing "AI for X"

Actors
Who submits, handles, approves
Who is affected

Triggers
What starts the work
Volume and timing

The ask
Whose problem?
Why now?

"AI to sort out complaints"

Decisions
What is decided, by whom
Can it be undone?

Outcomes
What good looks like
What failure costs

THE TAKEAWAY

Decompose before you design. Each branch becomes requirements, and each requirement gets a test.

Questions that turn a wish into requirements

ASK ABOUT	THE QUESTION	MERESIDE COMPLAINTS
Volume	How many, how fast, how spiky?	About 3,000 a month
Current process	Who does what today, and how long?	Handlers classify and reply
Exceptions	What is rare but serious?	Vulnerable customers
Decision owner	Who signs the outcome?	A handler approves every reply
Constraints	Data, region, audit, regulation?	UK or EU processing, full audit

THE TIEBREAKER

Ask about today's process first. You cannot measure improvement without a baseline.

Who discovery must hear from

STAKEHOLDER	WHY THEY MATTER	MERESIDE EXAMPLE
Sponsor	Funds it, owns the outcome	Chief operating officer
Business owner	Accountable for decisions	Head of complaints
Front-line users	Know the real process	Complaint handlers
Affected people	Bear the errors	Members who complain
Control functions	Can block launch	DPO, compliance, risk committee
Operators	Run it afterwards	IT service team

THE TIEBREAKER

A stakeholder you miss in discovery, you meet at launch, as a blocker.

Functional or non-functional?

FUNCTIONAL: WHAT IT DOES

Behaviour

- Classify each complaint by type
- Summarise the customer's case
- Draft a reply for a handler
- Flag possible vulnerability
- Route to the right team

NON-FUNCTIONAL: HOW WELL, WITHIN WHAT LIMITS

Qualities and constraints

- Draft ready within an agreed time
- Cost per complaint within budget
- Processing stays in the UK or EU
- Every draft and approval recorded
- Available in contact-centre hours

THE TIEBREAKER

If it describes a behaviour, it is functional. If it limits or qualifies a behaviour, it is non-functional.

Non-functional requirements that shape a Claude design

CATEGORY	EXAMPLE	WHAT IT SHAPES
Latency	First token in 2 s at p95	Tier, streaming, live or batch
Cost	Agreed cost per task	Model, caching, Batch, routing
Data and region	UK or EU processing only	Platform and region
Audit	Inputs, versions, approver kept	Logging and retention
Quality floor	Accuracy on the eval set	Model, prompt, retrieval

THE TIEBREAKER

These choose the platform and model. Collect them before validating.

Success criteria and failure thresholds

- **Success criteria:** the bar for going live, measured on a representative set.
- **Failure thresholds:** the line that blocks release, or triggers rollback after launch.
- **Agreed with the owner, before the build,** and written down.
- **Per dimension:** quality, latency, cost, safety, not one blended score.
- **Not:** "when the team is happy", or a threshold chosen after seeing results.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Criteria decide go-live. Thresholds decide stop. Both are set before anyone sees a result.

The discovery sequence

01
Goals
Outcomes, owner, stakeholders.

02
Today
Current process, volumes, baseline.

03
Requirements
Functional and non-functional.

04
Criteria
Success criteria, failure thresholds.

05
Risks
Constraints, assumptions, open questions.

06
Validate
Prototype and evaluate against criteria.

ON THE EXAM

Goals and non-functional requirements come before validation. A prototype tests requirements. It does not replace them.

Workshops, and what each must produce

WORKSHOP	WHO ATTENDS	MUST PRODUCE
Goals and outcomes	Sponsor, business owner	Outcomes, priorities, owner
Process walk-through	Front-line staff, team leads	Current steps, volumes, exceptions
Constraints	Security, DPO, compliance, IT	Testable data, region, audit rules
Success criteria	Owner, quality lead, risk	Criteria, thresholds, eval owner

THE TIEBREAKER

A workshop that ends without a written, owned output was a meeting.

Anthropic's prerequisites, before prompt engineering

- **A clear definition** of the success criteria for your use case.
- **Some ways to empirically test** against those criteria.
- **A first draft prompt** you want to improve.
- **"If not, spend time establishing that first."**
- **Not every criterion is a prompt problem:** latency and cost may need a different model.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Discovery's deliverable is the first two items. Without them, prompt work has no target.

Traceability: every requirement has a source and a test

REQUIREMENT	SOURCE	TEST
Flag possible vulnerability	Head of complaints	Recall on labelled cases
UK or EU processing only	Data protection officer	Platform and region review
A handler approves every reply	Model risk committee	Audit sample of approvals
Mandatory regulatory wording	Compliance	Automated check on every draft

THE TIEBREAKER

A requirement nobody owns is a guess. A requirement nobody can test is a wish.

What discovery hands to design

- **Problem statement** and outcomes, with a named owner.
- **Current process and baseline** measures.
- **Requirements,** functional and non-functional, each traced and testable.
- **Success criteria and failure thresholds,** and who owns the evaluation set.
- **Constraints, assumptions, risks** and open questions, each with an owner.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> If design has to guess, discovery is not finished.

Discovery traps the exam likes

- **Designing in week one** because the sponsor is impatient.
- **Taking the first solution named** ("we need a chatbot") as the requirement.
- **Hearing only the sponsor,** never the people who do the work.
- **Leaving non-functional requirements** until load testing.
- **Vague constraints** such as "secure" or "fast", with no owner or test.
- **Using Claude to draft from transcripts is fine;** stakeholders confirm every line.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> When an option skips straight to building, look for the one that asks the next question.

> Mereside's chief operating officer asks Corvane for "AI to sort out complaints".
>
> She wants design to start next week.

What should Corvane do first?

A Start the design with a complaints agent, and refine it once the first demo is seen

B Build a quick chatbot prototype so the business can react to something real

C Run short structured discovery: actors, volumes, decisions, outcomes, constraints, and success criteria

D Ask Anthropic for a reference complaints solution, and adopt its requirements as Mereside's own

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should Corvane do first?

A Start the design with a complaints agent, and refine it once the first demo is seen

Designs before anyone knows the problem.

B Build a quick chatbot prototype so the business can react to something real

A demo answers a question nobody has asked.

C Run short structured discovery: actors, volumes, decisions, outcomes, constraints, and success criteria

Decomposes the ask, then designs.

D Ask Anthropic for a reference complaints solution, and adopt its requirements as Mereside's own

A reference is not Mereside's requirements.

THE SIGNAL

A one-line ask gets discovery, not a design. Keep it short, but do it first.

> Tallyhawk's product lead wants a two-week prototype of an in-app assistant "to see what Claude can do".
>
> No goals, latency or cost limits, or data rules have been agreed.

What should Corvane do before validating anything?

A. Agree goals, success criteria and non-functional limits, then test the prototype against them

B. Run the prototype first, and derive the requirements from how real users react to it

C. Prototype on the most capable model, to show the best case

D. Write a complete specification before any prototype is allowed

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should Corvane do before validating anything?

A Agree goals, success criteria and non-functional limits, then test the prototype against them

A prototype then tests something.

B Run the prototype first, and derive the requirements from how real users react to it

Reactions are not requirements.

C Prototype on the most capable model, to show the best case

Best case on an unaffordable model misleads.

D Write a complete specification before any prototype is allowed

Over-corrects. Discovery, not a full spec.

THE SIGNAL

Goals and non-functional requirements come before validation.

> Mereside's constraints workshop ends with one agreed line: "customer data must be secure".
>
> The data protection officer and security lead both attended.

What should Corvane do with it?

A Record it as agreed, since both owners were in the room

B Apply the strongest encryption available, which satisfies any reading

C Defer the detail to the build phase, when engineers can judge it

D Break it into testable constraints, each with an owner and a check

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should Corvane do with it?

A Record it as agreed, since both owners were in the room

Agreement on a vague line is not a requirement.

B Apply the strongest encryption available, which satisfies any reading

Encryption answers one reading of secure.

C Defer the detail to the build phase, when engineers can judge it

Engineers would guess at policy.

D Break it into testable constraints, each with an owner and a check

Data classes, region, access, retention, audit: owned and testable.

THE SIGNAL

Vague constraints become testable constraints with owners. Otherwise they are wishes.

> Mereside's draft requirements say replies must be under two hundred words.
>
> Mandatory regulatory wording alone often takes half that. Nobody knows where the word limit came from.

What should Corvane do?

A Drop the word limit quietly, since regulation clearly wins

B Trace both requirements to their sources and owners, and resolve the conflict with them

C Keep the word limit, and shorten the regulatory wording

D Ask Claude to fit both into the limit as best it can

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should Corvane do?

A Drop the word limit quietly, since regulation clearly wins

Probably right, but undocumented and unowned.

B Trace both requirements to their sources and owners, and resolve the conflict with them

Owners decide. The record shows why.

C Keep the word limit, and shorten the regulatory wording

Mandatory wording cannot be shortened.

D Ask Claude to fit both into the limit as best it can

Hides a requirements conflict in a prompt.

THE SIGNAL

Conflicts are resolved by owners, through traceability. Not quietly, and not in the prompt.

> Mereside's sponsor proposes going live with complaints triage "when the team is happy with it".
>
> No measures or thresholds have been agreed.

What should Corvane propose?

A. Agree success criteria and failure thresholds per dimension with the owner, now

B. Go live when the sponsor signs off a demonstration

C. Run a pilot first, then set the thresholds from whatever its results show

D. Set a target of perfect accuracy, so nothing harmful gets through

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should Corvane propose?

A Agree success criteria and failure thresholds per dimension with the owner, now

Gates agreed before results exist.

B Go live when the sponsor signs off a demonstration

A demo is not evidence.

C Run a pilot first, then set the thresholds from whatever its results show

Thresholds set after results get bent to fit.

D Set a target of perfect accuracy, so nothing harmful gets through

Unachievable, so the gate is ignored.

THE SIGNAL

Criteria and thresholds are agreed before anyone sees a result.

> A Corvane analyst used Claude to turn eight hours of Quillon workshop transcripts into forty requirements.
>
> She plans to send the list to Quillon as final.

What should Corvane's lead architect do?

A Send it as final, since Claude summarised the transcripts faithfully and quickly

B Ban Claude from discovery work, to avoid errors

C Ask Claude to rate its confidence in each requirement

D Treat it as a draft, confirmed line by line with each source stakeholder

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should Corvane's lead architect do?

A Send it as final, since Claude summarised the transcripts faithfully and quickly

No one has checked a single line.

B Ban Claude from discovery work, to avoid errors

Throws away a useful drafting aid.

C Ask Claude to rate its confidence in each requirement

Self-ratings are not verification.

D Treat it as a draft, confirmed line by line with each source stakeholder

Claude drafts. Stakeholders confirm.

THE SIGNAL

Discernment in discovery: Claude drafts the list, people confirm it.

> Corvane is sorting Mereside's complaints requirements into functional and non-functional.

Which two are non-functional requirements? Choose two.

A Classify each complaint by type

B Processing stays in the UK or EU

C Draft a reply for a handler to approve

D Every draft and approval is recorded and kept

E Flag complaints from possibly vulnerable customers

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which two are non-functional requirements? Choose two.

A Classify each complaint by type

A behaviour: functional.

B Processing stays in the UK or EU

A constraint on where it runs.

C Draft a reply for a handler to approve

A behaviour: functional.

D Every draft and approval is recorded and kept

A quality of the system: auditability.

E Flag complaints from possibly vulnerable customers

A behaviour, even though it matters a lot.

THE SIGNAL

Behaviours are functional. Limits and qualities are non-functional, however important the behaviour.

In five lines

- **Decompose the ask:** actors, triggers, decisions, outcomes, constraints.
- **Functional is behaviour;** non-functional is limits and qualities, and shapes the design.
- **Goals and NFRs before validation;** a prototype tests requirements.
- **Criteria and thresholds** agreed with the owner before any result.
- **Trace every requirement** to a source, an owner and a test.

COMING UP

Next: communicating decisions to every audience, and recording them in ADRs.